KINGDOM LIFE MINISTRY

The First of the Harvest

Firstfruits: The Wave Sheaf, the Empty Tomb, and the Harvest Still Coming

A Midrash Study on Reshit, Leviticus 23:9-14

Scripture quoted from the World English Bible, divine name rendered YHWH, Elohim, and Adonai, with Yahshua and Messiah restored. Torah is referred to throughout as the instructions of YHWH.

THE HEART OF IT

In the middle of the week of Unleavened Bread, YHWH told Israel to bring the first sheaf of the barley harvest to the priest, to be waved before him and accepted for the people. Nothing of the new harvest could be eaten until that first sheaf was given to him.

Paul says Yahshua is that first sheaf: **Messiah has been raised from the dead. He became the first fruit of those who are asleep.** The first of the harvest went up. The rest of the harvest is coming.

HOW TO READ THIS HANDOUT

Commanded means the instruction is written plainly. **Interpretive** means a reasonable reading Scripture does not state outright. **Conviction** means it is how we at Kingdom Life walk it out. Where Scripture stops speaking, we do not call our reading a commandment.

SECTION I

The Appointed Time Itself

> *Speak to the children of Israel, and tell them, "When you have come into the land which I give to you, and shall reap its harvest, then you shall bring the sheaf of the first fruits of your harvest to the priest. He shall wave the sheaf before YHWH, to be accepted for you. On the next day after the Sabbath the priest shall wave it."*
> **LEVITICUS 23:10-11**

> *You shall eat neither bread, nor roasted grain, nor fresh grain, until this same day, until you have brought the offering of your Elohim. This is a statute forever throughout your generations in all your dwellings.*
> **LEVITICUS 23:14**

Notice three things in the text. First, this instruction begins **when you have come into the land**. It is tied to the land's harvest and to the priest. Second, it falls on **the next day after the Sabbath** during the feast. Third, unlike Passover's high days, Leviticus 23:9-14 does not call this day a holy convocation and does not command rest. Firstfruits is an offering day, not a Sabbath. **Stated in the text.** We say that plainly so no one is told they must rest on a day Scripture did not make a rest day.

The Words

- ***Reshit (H7225).*** First, beginning, the first part or the best part. It is the same word that opens the Bible: *bereshit*, in the beginning (Genesis 1:1). The first sheaf is the *reshit* of the harvest.
- ***Omer (H6016).*** A sheaf, a bundle of cut grain. *Omer reshit* is the sheaf of the first fruits (Leviticus 23:10). The same word is also used for a measure, as with the manna in Exodus 16.
- ***Nuph (H5130) and tenuphah (H8573).*** To wave, to lift and move back and forth, and the wave offering itself. The priest lifted the sheaf before YHWH.
- ***Ratzon (H7522).*** Acceptance, favor, delight. The sheaf was waved **to be accepted for you** (Leviticus 23:11). The first was offered so that the rest would be received.
- ***Bikkurim (H1061).*** First ripe fruits. A related word, used most for the wheat firstfruits at Shavuot (Numbers 28:26). Both words point to the same principle: the first belongs to YHWH.
- ***Aparche (G536).*** The Greek for firstfruits. The Septuagint uses it at Leviticus 23:10, and Paul uses it for the risen Messiah (1 Corinthians 15:20, 23), for Israel's root and branches (Romans 11:16), and for believers (James 1:18; Romans 8:23).

SECTION II

The Next Day After the Sabbath

The Hebrew of Leviticus 23:11 is *mimochorat haShabbat*, from the morrow of the Sabbath. Which Sabbath? This question has divided readers for over two thousand years, and it matters, because Shavuot is counted from this day (Leviticus 23:15-16).

- **The weekly Sabbath reading.** Firstfruits falls on the first day of the week that follows the weekly Sabbath during Unleavened Bread. The count of seven Sabbaths then lands Shavuot on the day after the seventh Sabbath, a first day of the week (Leviticus 23:15-16). This keeps *Shabbat* meaning the same thing in both verses.
- **The high day reading.** Firstfruits falls on the sixteenth of the month, the day after the first high day of Unleavened Bread. This became the Pharisees' reckoning and is the rabbinic calendar today.

Conviction: at Kingdom Life we keep the weekly Sabbath reading. It lets the word Sabbath mean the weekly Sabbath in verse 11 the same way it does in verses 15 and 16, and it places Firstfruits on the first day of the week, the very morning the women found the tomb empty.

> **FACT CHECK BEFORE YOU TEACH IT**
>
> The Septuagint at Leviticus 23:11 reads **on the morrow of the first day**, which supports the high day reading. Yet at 23:15 the Septuagint reads from the morrow of the Sabbaths. So the Greek text itself is not uniform on this question.
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> Be honest about this when you teach it. The weekly Sabbath reading rests on the Hebrew text and its internal consistency, not on the Septuagint. **Hold it as a conviction, and do not tell anyone the other reading has no textual support.**

SECTION III

The Empty Tomb on Firstfruits

> *But now Messiah has been raised from the dead. He became the first fruit of those who are asleep. For since death came by man, the resurrection of the dead also came by man.*
> **1 CORINTHIANS 15:20-21**

Paul did not choose the word firstfruits at random. He was writing a letter that already used the feast language of Passover and Unleavened Bread (1 Corinthians 5:7-8), and he later mentions staying in Ephesus until Pentecost (16:8). When he calls the risen Messiah the *aparche*, he is pointing straight at Leviticus 23:10.

We hold that Yahshua was crucified on Wednesday, laid in the tomb before the high day began, and rose after three days and three nights (Matthew 12:40). When the women came very early on the first day of the week, the tomb was already empty (Matthew 28:1-6; Mark 16:2-6; John 20:1). That first day was the morrow after the weekly Sabbath, the day the first sheaf was waved. **Conviction, resting on the weekly Sabbath reading and the Wednesday timeline.** The empty tomb on the first day of the week is stated in all four Gospels.

> *Most certainly I tell you, unless a grain of wheat falls into the earth and dies, it remains by itself alone. But if it dies, it bears much fruit.*
> **JOHN 12:24**

Yahshua described his own death and resurrection as grain going into the ground and coming up as a harvest. The firstfruits sheaf is grain that came up out of the ground first.

Do Not Hold Me

When Mary recognized him on that first morning, Yahshua told her, **Don't hold me, for I haven't yet ascended to my Father** (John 20:17). Later that same week he invited Thomas to touch his hands and side (John 20:27). Some see the risen Messiah presenting himself before the Father that first day, as the sheaf was presented before YHWH, before he was handled by his disciples. **Interpretive.** The text does not explain why he said it; we offer the picture without building doctrine on it.

Not Only Him

Matthew records that after his resurrection, tombs were opened and many bodies of the holy ones who had fallen asleep were raised, came out, and appeared to many in the holy city (Matthew 27:52-53). A sheaf is not one stalk. It is a bundle. **The event is stated in the text; the sheaf picture is interpretive.**

SECTION IV

Each in His Own Order: The Harvest Still Coming

> *But each in his own order: Messiah the first fruits, then those who are Messiah's, at his coming.*
> **1 CORINTHIANS 15:23**

Firstfruits guarantees the rest of the harvest. The first sheaf was offered because a whole field was standing behind it. Paul lays out the order: Messiah first, then those who belong to him **at his coming**. The rest of the harvest is the

resurrection at the last trumpet, when the dead are raised and the living are changed (1 Corinthians 15:51-52; 1 Thessalonians 4:16-17).

At Kingdom Life we hold that this gathering comes at his return after the tribulation, when he sends his angels with a great sound of a trumpet to gather his chosen ones (Matthew 24:29-31). That is the fall harvest, Yom Teruah, which the Trumpets handout covers. **Conviction.** Firstfruits in the spring is the promise. The trumpet in the fall is the harvest.

Scripture also calls believers firstfruits. Of his own will he gave birth to us by the word of truth, that we should be a kind of first fruits of his creatures (James 1:18). We have the first fruits of the Spirit and wait for the redemption of our body (Romans 8:23). Revelation 14:4 calls the 144,000 first fruits to Elohim and to the Lamb.

SECTION V

If the First Is Holy, the Branches Are Holy

> *If the first fruit is holy, so is the lump. If the root is holy, so are the branches.*
> **ROMANS 11:16**

This verse opens Paul's olive tree passage, the very chapter where he says Gentile believers are grafted in among the natural branches and share in the root (Romans 11:17-24). Paul ties the firstfruits principle directly to the grafted in. What is offered first sanctifies what comes after it. The branches are holy because of the root they are joined to, not because of where they grew up.

> **GRAFTED INTO THE HARVEST**
>
> You do not keep Firstfruits to become part of Israel. You keep it because the Firstfruits has already made you part of the harvest. **The first sheaf was accepted for you** (Leviticus 23:11), and everything joined to him is received with him.

SECTION VI

Keeping Firstfruits Without the Temple

Of all the spring appointed times, Firstfruits is the one most tied to the land and the priest. The instruction begins **when you have come into the land**, the sheaf is from your harvest, and the priest waves it (Leviticus 23:10-11). It came with a burnt offering, a meal offering, and a drink offering (23:12-13). There is no priest waving a sheaf in Jerusalem today, and we do not wave one in our living rooms as if we were priests. **Commanded, and not something we can do now.**

So what still stands? Read the text closely:

- **Count the days.** The count of fifty days to Shavuot begins on this day (Leviticus 23:15-16). Counting needs no altar. **Commanded.**
- **Worship the risen Firstfruits.** The reality the sheaf pointed to has already happened. He is risen (Matthew 28:6), and the High Priest himself has entered heaven to appear before Elohim for us (Hebrews 9:24). **Stated in the text.**

- **Honor YHWH with the first of your increase.** Honor YHWH with your substance, with the first fruits of all your increase (Proverbs 3:9). The principle of giving him the first, before you use the rest, is not tied to an altar. **Stated in the text.**
- **Hold back the new grain.** Leviticus 23:14 says no new grain was eaten until the offering, and it adds **in all your dwellings**. Some households choose to hold off on new grain products until this day. Since the offering itself cannot be brought, whether that part still binds is a fair question. **Interpretive.** If you do it, do it as remembrance, not as a test of anyone's obedience.

Firstfruits is also the day that proves the gospel. If the Firstfruits did not rise, Paul says, our faith is vain and we are still in our sins (1 Corinthians 15:17). Every believer anywhere in the world can gather on this morning and say the one thing the whole harvest rests on: **he is not here, for he has risen.**

SECTION VII

What We Leave Out and Why

Rabbinic tradition counts the omer from the sixteenth of the month and attaches its own blessings, a season of mourning customs, and a minor holiday on the thirty third day of the count. None of those are written in Scripture.

Church tradition, on the other hand, replaced this appointed time with Easter, a date set by a church council formula and carrying a name and customs that do not come from the text. The resurrection is real and central. The way it was taken out of YHWH's calendar and placed into another one is not. We keep the day he appointed and let it speak for itself.

SECTION VIII

Walking It Out

1. **Find the day.** On the weekly Sabbath reading, Firstfruits is the first day of the week that falls during the seven days of Unleavened Bread.
2. **Rise early.** The women came while it was still dark (John 20:1). Gather your household at sunrise and read the resurrection accounts together.
3. **Give the first.** Set apart a first portion before you spend the rest, as a statement that it all belongs to him.
4. **Start the count.** Day one of fifty begins. Mark it on the calendar, and count each day to Shavuot.
5. **Pray for the harvest.** Ask YHWH to bring in the rest of the harvest. Name the people you are praying for by name.
6. **Bury something.** John 12:24 says the grain has to die to bear fruit. Ask him what pride or grudge in you needs to go into the ground this year.

SECTION IX

Cross Reference Index

Primary texts: Leviticus 23:9-14; 1 Corinthians 15:20-23

The morrow after the Sabbath: Leviticus 23:11, 15-16; Joshua 5:10-12

The resurrection on the first day: Matthew 12:40; Matthew 28:1-7; Mark 16:1-6; Luke 24:1-7; John 20:1-18

Grain into the ground: John 12:23-24; 1 Corinthians 15:35-44

The sheaf of holy ones: Matthew 27:50-53

The harvest at his coming: 1 Corinthians 15:23, 51-52; 1 Thessalonians 4:13-17; Matthew 24:29-31

Believers as firstfruits: James 1:18; Romans 8:23; Revelation 14:1-5; Jeremiah 2:3

Root and branches: Romans 11:16-24; Ephesians 2:12-19

Giving the first: Proverbs 3:9-10; Exodus 23:19; Deuteronomy 26:1-11

High Priest in heaven: Hebrews 8:1-2; Hebrews 9:11-12, 24

NOTES

Personal Notes and Convictions

Kingdom Life Ministry
Restoring YHWH's design for marriage, family, forgiveness, and deliverance.

Walk in truth, walk in light. Shalom.